Privilege to Complain

By Rudy K. Francisco and Andrea Gibson

On May 26th, 2003,
Aron Ralston was hiking,
a boulder fell on his right hand,
he waited four days,
he then amputated
his own arm with a pocketknife.

On New Year's Eve,
a woman was bungee jumping,
the cord broke,
she fell into a river
and had to swim back to land
in crocodile-infested waters
with a broken collarbone.

Claire Champlin was smashed in the face
by a five-pound watermelon
being propelled by a slingshot.

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Matthew Brobst was hit by a javelin.

David Striegl was actually
punched in the mouth by a kangaroo.

The most amazing part about these stories
is when asked about the experience
they all smiled, shrugged, and said
"I guess things could have been worse."

INTRODUCTION

Optimists see: *A glass half full . . .*
Pessimists see: *A glass half empty. . .*
Chronic complainers see: *A glass that is slightly chipped holding water that isn't cold enough, (shift voice to become progressively more put out and in first person as introduction continues) probably because it's tap water when I asked for bottled water and wait, there's a smudge on the rim, too, which means the glass wasn't cleaned properly and now I'll probably end up with some kind of virus. Why do these things always happen to me?!*

The Privilege to Complain – A Program designed to perhaps make us think twice about what we choose to complain about with poems by Rudy K. Francisco and Andrea Gibson.

Complainers by Rudy K. Francisco

So go ahead,
tell me that you're having a bad day.

Tell me about the traffic.
Tell me about your boss.
Tell me about the job
you've been trying to quit for the past four years.
Tell me the morning is
just a townhouse burning to the ground
and the snooze button is a fire extinguisher.

Tell me the alarm clock
stole the keys to your smile,
drove it into 7 am
and the crash totaled your happiness.
Tell me.
Tell me how blessed are we to have tragedy
so small it can fit on the tips of our tongues.

When Evan lost his legs he was speechless.
When my cousin was assaulted
she didn't speak for 48 hours.

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When my uncle was murdered,
we had to send out a search party
to find my father's voice.

Most people have no idea
that tragedy and silence
have the exact same address.

When your day is a museum of disappointments,
hanging from events that were outside of your control,
when you feel like your guardian
angel put in his two week notice two months ago
and just decided not to tell you,
when it seems like God
is just a babysitter that's always on the phone,
when you get punched in the esophagus
by a fistful of life,

Remember,
every year
two million people die of dehydration.
So it doesn't matter if
the glass is half full or half empty.

There's water in the cup.
Drink it and stop complaining.

Muscle is created by lifting things
that are designed to weigh us down.
When your shoulders feel heavy
stand up straight and call it exercise.
Life is a gym membership
with a really complicated cancellation policy.

Remember,
you will survive,
things could be worse,
and we are never given
anything we can't handle.
When the whole world crumbles,
you have to build a new one
out of all the pieces that are still here.

Remember,
you are still here.

The human heart beats
approximately 4,000 times per hour

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and each pulse,
each throb,
each palpitation is a trophy
engraved with the words
"You are still alive."
You are still alive.
So act like it.

SOURCE INFORMATION

Author: Rudy K Francisco
Book: Helium (Pg 91-94)
ISBN: 978-1943735198
Publisher: Button Poetry
Date (Month/Year): Nov 2017

TRANSITION

In the next selection, Andrea Gibson theorizes that the reason Americans complain about small things and suffer from depression at alarming rates is because we feel we are unable to solve the bigger issues in our society and in our world.

When the Bough Breaks by Andrea Gibson

When the Bough Breaks by Andrea Gibson (Pg 73-76)

It's two a.m.
The emergency room psychiatrist looks up from his
clipboard
with eyes paid to care
and asks me if I see people who aren't really there.
I say, "I see people
how the hell am I supposed to know
if they're really there or not?"
He doesn't laugh
neither do I.
The math's not on my side
ten stitches and one lie.
I swear I wasn't trying to die.
I just wanted to see what my pulse looked like from the
inside.

Fast forward one year.
I'm standing in an auditorium behind a microphone
reading a poem to four hundred Latino high school kids

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who live with the breath of the INS
crawling up their mother's backbones
and I am frantically hiding my scars
'cause the last thing I want these kids to know
is that I ever thought that my life was too hard.

I've never seen a bomb drop.
I've never felt hunger.
I've also never seen lightning strike
but we've all heard thunder
and it doesn't take a genius to tell something's burning.
The smoke rises between us,
forming walls so high
they split the sky like slit wrists
and then the stars fall like blood.
We're all left with nothing, but a death wish.

He said, "call me by my true name
I am the child in uganda all skin and bone"
Do you remember the rest?
how about this one, America
Jesus wept.
America, Jesus wept

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but look at your eyes
dry as the desert sand
dusting the edges of your soldier's wedding bands.
Look at your soul playing dead
because your ribcage is abu ghraib
is san quintin
is guantanamo bay
and your heart had beaten them so many times
they bleed the moon.

Do you know children in Palestine fly kites to prove that they are still free?
Can you imagine how that string must feel between their fingers
as they kneel in the cinders of our missile heads
You can count the dead by the colours in the sky

The bough is breaking.
The cradle is falling.
Right now a six-year old girl is crutched in a ditch in Lebanon
wishing on falling bombs.
Right now our government is recording the test scores of

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black and Latino 4th graders
to see how many prison beds will be needed in the year 2021.
Right now there's a man on the street outside that door
with outstretched hands full of heart beats no one can hear.
He has cheeks like torn sheet music,
Every tear a broken crescendo falling on closed ears.
At his side there's a girl with eyes like an anthem
that no one stands up for.

Doctor, our insanity is not that we see people who aren't there.
It's that we ignore the ones who are.
Till we find ourselves scarred and ashamed
walking into emergency rooms at three a.m.
flooded with a pain we cannot name or explain
because we are bleeding from the outside in.
Skin is not impervious.
Cultures built on greed and destruction do not pick and choose who they kill.

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Do we really believe our need for Prozac
has nothing to do with Baghdad,
with Kabul, with the Mexican border
with the thousands of US school kids
bleeding through budget cuts that will never heal
to fuel war tanks?

Thank god for denial.
Thank god we can afford the makeup
to pile upon the face of it all.
Look at the pretty world.
Look at all the smiling people
and the sky with a missile between her teeth
and a steeple through her heart
and not a single star left to hold her

And the voices of a thousand broken nations saying
"wake me, wake me, when the American dream is over"

SOURCE INFORMATION

Author: Andrea Gibson
Book: Pole Dancing to Gospel Hymns (Pg 73-76)
ISBN: 978-0981521305
Publisher: Write Bloody Publishing

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Date (Month/Year): June 2008

AWARD HISTORY

2016 National Qualifier – MS
2021 National Qualifier – MS
2022 National Qualifier – MS
KS State Qualifier

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